



Winter Storm and Outage Checklist

Trees and power lines share the same canyons up here, so outages come with the territory. Most of this list takes one weekend afternoon, and it turns a three-day outage from a crisis into an inconvenience.

BEFORE THE STORM: SET UP ONCE

- ☐ Sign up for CruzAware, the county's emergency alert system, at cruzaware.org, and register more than one contact method. For basic text alerts, text your ZIP code to 888777.
- ☐ Set up PG&E outage alerts. Account holders get outage notifications for their service address automatically once contact info is current. Renters, or anyone watching a second property, can get address-level alerts through the PG&E outage map with no account needed.
- ☐ Save two numbers in every phone in the house: PG&E's 24-hour outage line, 1-800-743-5002, and county road dispatch, (831) 477-3999.
- ☐ If anyone in your home relies on electricity for medical needs, enroll them in PG&E's Medical Baseline Program now. Eligibility is based on medical need, not income, and enrollees get extra advance notifications before a planned shutoff. Write down each device's battery runtime and the point at which you would relocate somewhere with power.
- ☐ Ask your pharmacist how long each refrigerated medication lasts without power, and write the answer on the box.
- ☐ Put a battery-powered or battery-backup carbon monoxide detector near every sleeping area, and check it when you check your smoke alarms.
- ☐ Put an appliance thermometer in the refrigerator and another in the freezer.
- ☐ Store water: one gallon per person per day is the common rule of thumb, and more is better when outages can run multiple days. If you are on a well, no electricity means no pump, so treat stored water as a must. Keep separate jugs or buckets for flushing toilets.
- ☐ Store generator fuel outside the house, never indoors.
- ☐ If you want a generator to run household circuits rather than extension cords, have an electrician install a transfer switch or equivalent equipment. Never plug a generator into a wall outlet; backfed power can injure the crews working to restore your neighborhood.
- ☐ Trade phone numbers with neighbors before storm season. Know who is older, lives alone, is on a well, or depends on medical equipment. A text thread for your road costs nothing.

PLANNED SHUTOFFS HAPPEN TOO

During dry, windy, high fire-risk weather, PG&E may call a Public Safety Power Shutoff (PSPS) so its lines can't spark a wildfire. PG&E tries to alert customers ahead by email, phone, and text, but the first alert may not come until the same day power goes off. Don't count on long notice; have supplies ready before fire season.

WHEN THE POWER GOES OUT

- ☐ Check the PG&E outage map for your address. If your outage isn't showing, report it online or call 1-800-743-5002. Outages on far tap lines sometimes need a phone call before anyone knows they're dead.
- ☐ Unplug electronics and appliances; power sometimes comes back with surges. Leave one lamp on so you know when service returns.

- ☐ Keep the refrigerator and freezer closed. Unopened, a refrigerator keeps food safe about 4 hours. A full freezer holds about 48 hours, a half-full one about 24. Eat from the pantry first.
- ☐ Run a generator outside only, more than 20 feet from any windows, doors, and vents. Never inside a home or garage, even with the doors and windows open. Carbon monoxide is odorless, colorless, and kills people in their sleep.
- ☐ Keep the generator dry and out of the rain, let it cool before refueling, and use heavy-duty extension cords rated for the load.
- ☐ Check on the neighbors, especially anyone older, alone, on a well, or using powered medical equipment. A knock on the right door can matter more than everything else on this page.
- ☐ Downed line: call 911 first, then PG&E at 1-800-743-5000. Assume every line is live and keep people and pets far away.
- ☐ If you smell gas, leave the area first, then call 911, then report it to PG&E from somewhere safe.

AS THE OUTAGE STRETCHES ON

- ☐ Open the fridge only when you must; a cooler with ice extends your window.
- ☐ Toss perishables (meat, poultry, fish, eggs, leftovers) that spend more than 2 hours above 40 degrees. Never taste food to decide whether it's safe. When in doubt, throw it out.
- ☐ Frozen food that still has ice crystals, or that reads 40 degrees or below on a thermometer, can be safely refrozen.
- ☐ Refrigerated medicine: after a day without power, call your doctor or pharmacist right away about replacement, unless the label says otherwise.
- ☐ On San Lorenzo Valley Water District water and wondering how outages affect your neighborhood? Call the district at (831) 338-2153 and ask. Storing a few gallons is cheap insurance either way.